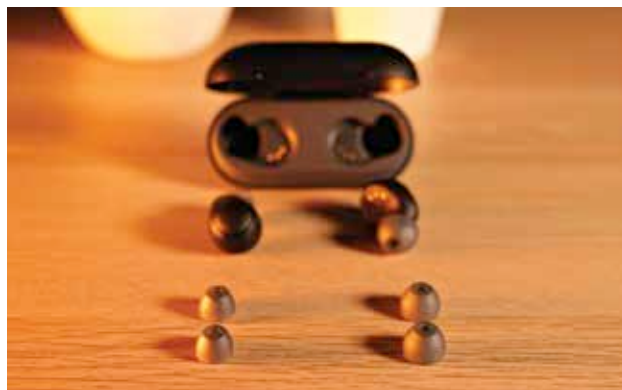




DSEE (Digital Sound Enhancement Engine), Sony's homegrown AI-based music upscaling technology, works like a charm on these earbuds. Having been someone who daily drives the Apple AirPods Pro (2nd Gen) paired with Apple Music, I was surprised to see how well the earbuds handled upscaling. When listening to some of the tracks which I jam to on a daily basis, there were one-off instances where the processing did not go as I had expected it to. However, I cannot complain much, given how well it worked the rest of the time. Sony has only added support for SBC and AAC codecs, which I believe could have been better if they included LDAC or aptX as well.

PERFORMANCE

In terms of performance, Sony has made significant improvements to the sound signature of the earbuds. As you can see in the graph, the boost in the low frequencies, which drive the bass and the highs, balance each other out, and the mids, staying close to our baseline reading of Pink Noise, ensures that the sound signature is well-rounded, especially for the price.

Sony has now started focussing on products that are tuned for Indian audiences. With these earbuds, the sound signature is well suited for the genres like Bollywood, Pop, and Hip Hop, which have been all the rage amongst Indian audiences. When comparing the sound of these earbuds to the likes of Nothing Ear (2) and the Jabra Elite 4, in my opinion, these earbuds are much better suited for an audience that enjoys that thump in the bass. In case you do not like the bass or the boost in the highs is causing you

discomfort over longer periods of listening, then you can always go to the Sony Headphones Connect app and tune the audio to your liking. The EQ baked into the app has a fair number of presets as well, which ensures that the earbuds can be tuned to your liking.

As for the microphone, the Sonys did not disappoint me. I tested them in a variety of scenarios, and these earbuds were up to the mark in all of them. In situations where there was a LOT of noise, like a railway platform, there was some level of noise that seeped through to the receiver. However, apart from that, there was not much to complain about here.

Staying on the topic of noisy environments, let's talk about the noise cancellation of these earbuds. Given that these earbuds have a great fit in the ears, half the battle is won right there. At least in my case, where I got a snug fit with the small-sized ear tips. With ANC on, I could not hear the low-end rumbling sounds of the AC, which sits right above my head in the office. During my commutes to and fro from work on the train and in auto, the WF C700N earbuds did well to ensure that I could not hear most of the heavy sounds around me.

These earbuds pack the same hardware as Sony's high-end TWS earbuds. The only place where they have been held back from running away with best-in-class ANC is the software-level processing. So, it wasn't surprising to see that the earbuds did well in some of the most challenging situations as well. I would still say there is some room for improvement, especially with the handling of high-end sounds like shrill horns and the like. But, for the most part,

these earbuds hold their ground well.

In terms of battery life, these earbuds lasted about 4 and a half hours in our Pink Noise loop test with ANC on and volume set to 50 per cent, which is pretty close to Sony's claims of the 5-hour of battery life that these earbuds carry. And, when you are out of juice, you can harness the quick charge capability of the earbuds to ensure that you get a claimed 60-minute run time in just 10 minutes of charging!

VERDICT

The Sony WF C700N is a well-rounded pair of earbuds with a sound signature that would appeal to the masses in India and ANC that draws them hold their ground well. There are a few kinks, like the button-based control interface, which I would like Sony to work on. One last thing before I wrap up this review. Like it is with all audio products, please try these earbuds once before you take the plunge, as the fit is something that would make or break the experience for you. And if these do not fit well, then I would say, explore options like the Nothing Ear (2) which features a stem-based design or the Jabra Elite 4 which have a similar approach to their design, but manage to work wonders with their fit and overall product quality.

—Sativik Pandey

SPECIFICATIONS

Drivers: 5mm drivers | Battery Life: Up to 5 Hours with ANC on | IP Rating: IPX4 | DSEE: Yes | Active Noise Cancellation: Yes | Bluetooth Version: 5.2 | Supported Codecs: SBC, AAC

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